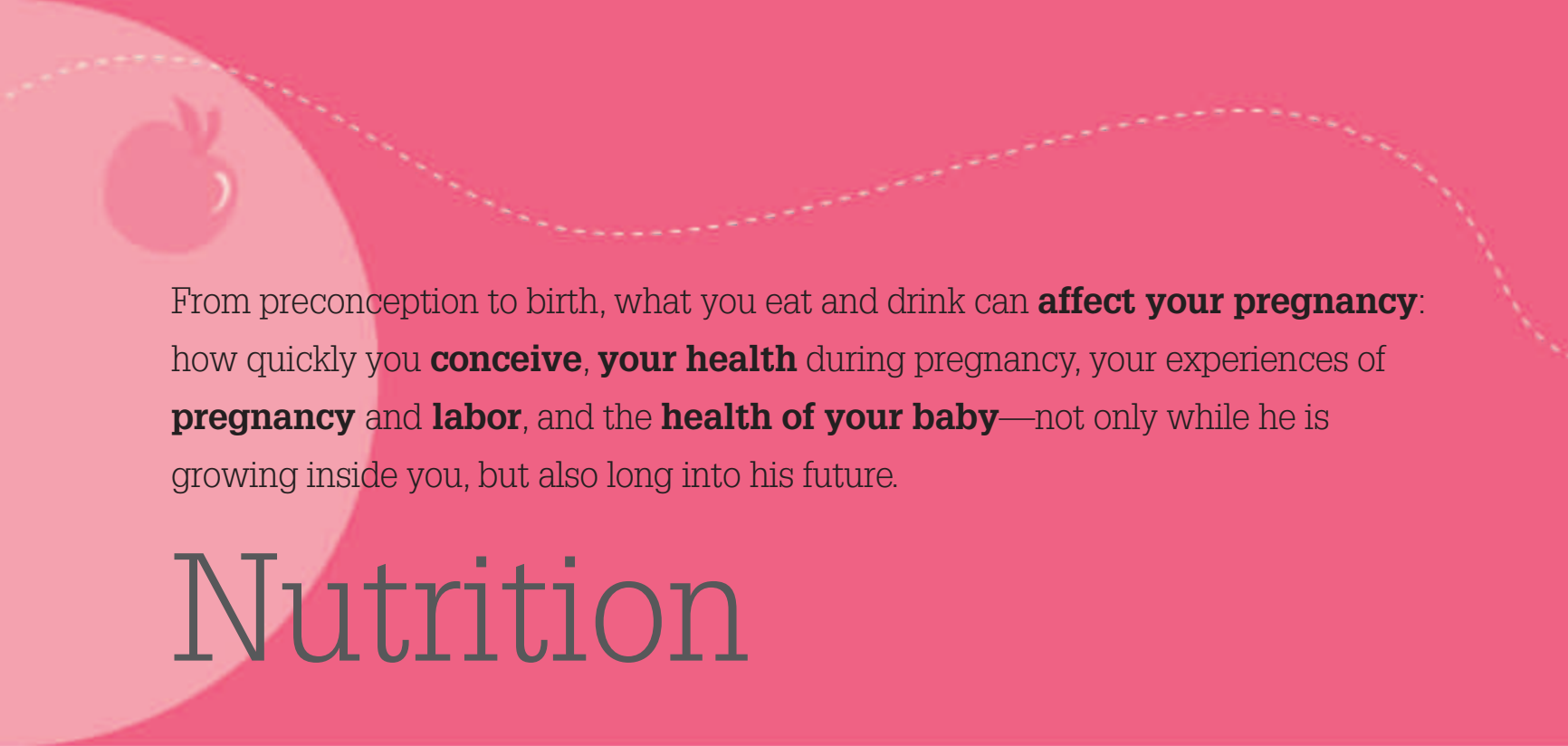




From preconception to birth, what you eat and drink can **affect your pregnancy**: how quickly you **conceive, your health** during pregnancy, your experiences of **pregnancy** and **labor**, and the **health of your baby**—not only while he is growing inside you, but also long into his future.

Nutrition

Eating to stay healthy

There are few experiences in your life that will demand as much of your body as pregnancy and childbirth. Preparing yourself by eating as well as you can is hugely beneficial—a healthy body helps make your experience of conception, pregnancy, and labor a positive one.

Our diets have changed dramatically over the course of the last 50 years; it seems normal now to eat prepared, processed, and refined foods regularly rather than always making meals and snacks from scratch ourselves. However, eating enough of the right nutrients is one of the most positive things you can take control of. Good nutrition doesn't need to be any more complicated than the general principles of eating a healthy, balanced diet—just be aware that what you stock in your cupboards and fridge and put on your plate is even more important than usual, both for your fertility and energy levels and for the health of your developing baby. You don't have to follow a rigid diet or eat

unpleasant foods: it's all about eating twice as well (and not twice as much) to ensure you receive the best nutrients from every mouthful.

Eating well at every stage

As soon as you conceive, you become the lifeline to your baby—everything you eat, drink, and breathe is broken down into molecules containing valuable nutrients and oxygen and transported through your bloodstream and placenta to the fetus. So it's important to have good habits in place from the start. This section gives advice on how you can prepare for and aid conception, including what supplements to take. Once you have conceived, you can read about eating for energy and health, what your baby needs, the best approach if you have an intolerance or you follow a special diet for personal or medical reasons, which foods to avoid, and advice on smoking and drugs. After the birth, you can learn about how to boost your recovery through good nutrition.